



Review

Reviewed Work(s): *Home and Work: Negotiating Boundaries through Everyday Life* by Christena E. Nippert-Eng

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projection model to explore how differential fertility and the intergenerational persistence of status interact to transform the distribution of schooling over time. There are two important contributions here. First, Mare assesses whether differential fertility by mother's education substantially retards growth over time in schooling levels (it doesn't); second, he has taken the first steps towards formally incorporating macrolevel demographic processes into models of status attainment.

In one of two theoretical contributions, Carol Heimer presents a theory of responsibility, arguing that personal responsibilities for care of kin are fundamentally different from positional responsibilities in the workplace. The former are actually fate-like *obligations* that are not easily relinquished, while the latter are strategic opportunities. Women are doubly constrained, according to Heimer, since they normally have little choice about whether to take on the obligation of care for other family members, which in turn limits their ability to strategically pursue positional opportunities in which responsibility is associated with resources, status, and career success. In effect, Heimer is adding sociological content to economists' supply-side account of role specialization among dual-earner couples, albeit with some of the same problematic essentialist assumptions about women's comparative advantage in kin-keeping activities.

In another theoretical contribution, Fligstein and Byrkjeflot offer a conceptual scheme for understanding the internal logics of employment systems based on vocationalism, professionalism, and managerialism, to explain how different configurations in the balance of power among workers, professionals, managers, and the state determine the trajectories that these systems take. The volume also includes a contribution by Tudor on gender and the social construction of intelligence.

The book ends with a critical essay by the editors that explains why the status attainment paradigm failed to produce a comprehensive framework for understanding inequality and highlights the challenges facing the field. A fitting tribute to John Pock, *Social Differentiation and Social Inequality* is also a worthy contribution to positivist scholarship on social inequality.

Close Relationships, Family, and the Life Course

Home and Work: Negotiating Boundaries through Everyday Life, by **Christena E. Nippert-Eng**. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1996. 325 pp. NPL cloth. ISBN: 0-226-58145-4. NPL paper. ISBN: 0-226-58146-2.

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How do individuals negotiate the boundaries between home and work, and how is this negotiation influenced by cultural and structural constraints? Christena Nippert-Eng addresses these questions in this innovative and engaging book. Nippert-Eng presents a comprehensive approach to the analysis of the intersection of home and work. This intersection is characterized by a continuum ranging from integration to segmentation. Home and work are integrated when there is little distinction between them in terms of physical artifacts such as calendars and clothing, rituals such as eating and breaks, time and place of work activities, interaction across domains, and social contacts and friends. Segmentation exists when these dimensions are distinct for home and work. Segmentors experience two distinct, realm-specific mentalities and alternate between two different "selves" depending on the realm. Nippert-Eng focuses on boundary work that reflects and determines the extent of integration/segmentation for a given individual. Boundary work is mainly a mental activity that is enacted through practical activities. Boundaries must be placed or located between home and work (the primary challenge for integrators) and must be transcended as one moves from one realm to the other (a more difficult process for segmentors).

Nippert-Eng empirically examines boundary work among scientists, personnel administrators, and machinists employed by a major research laboratory in the Northeast. Her data include extensive personal interviews with 72 employees as well as informal discussions and site visits. The interviewees

represent several hierarchical levels in the organization and diverse life course/family situations among those living with at least one significant other.

Most of the book describes how individuals place and transcend various aspects of the boundaries between home and work and the factors influencing these processes. One chapter discusses how segmentors and integrators differ in their use of such artifacts as calendars, keys, address books, and photographs, and in ways of talking, dressing, eating, drinking, and reading at home and work. Another focuses on how segmentors and integrators enact mental and physical transitions between realms through rituals associated with preparing for work in the morning, leaving work in the evening, commuting, using caffeine and alcohol, and making and receiving phone calls.

Nippert-Eng then analyzes a range of constraints originating in the work and home realms that influence boundary work. Bureaucratic work units encourage segmenting, greedy units engender integration, whereas discretionary workplaces facilitate individual choice. These workplace characteristics operate at several levels of the organization but are not necessarily consistent across levels: A bureaucratic department may include some greedy work groups, for example. Occupational norms also are important; scientists are socialized differently from machinists. At home the expectations and demands of spouses and children are critical. Boundary work varies according to an individual's view of the sacredness of children and position as primary or secondary parent. Characteristics associated with the physical environment are important in both realms, e.g., amount of space and privacy.

The author's analysis of boundary work between home and work is enlightening and compelling. Nippert-Eng is especially adept at showing how mental processes are enacted through physical activities and describing how various constraints influence these processes. She brings the analysis of the intersection between these two realms into the domain of the study of everyday life. The major, though not serious, weakness in the book is Nippert-Eng's treatment of gender. She assesses the role of gender throughout her analysis, for example, of pregnancy as an intrusion of the

family realm into the work setting. She also discusses the relevance of women being more likely than men to serve as primary parents. However, her examination of gender in the context of work-based constraints is more limited. In many ways gender could serve as a bridging concept between the home and work realms.

This book raises important issues for policy. Despite the cultural priority given to segmentation, this emphasis varies by occupational level. Integrating occupations tend to be concentrated among professionals and managers. Women are disproportionately found in lower-status segmenting occupations. Both segmentation and integration have advantages and disadvantages. Segmentors have less discretion at work and find it more difficult to make the transition between home and work. However, they are free from the "greediness" associated with integration, e.g., work-based interruptions at home and long, unpredictable work hours. Many work-family policies such as onsite child care and flexible work hours and places encourage integration with its accompanying work demands. Thus, these policies need to be considered in the context of complex interactions among workplace cultures, occupational status, and gender.

Ageism, the Aged and Aging in America: On Being Old in an Alienated Society, by **Ursula Adler Falk** and **Gerhard Falk**. Springfield, IL: Charles C Thomas, 1997. 271 pp. NPL cloth. ISBN: 0-398-06765-1. NPL paper. ISBN: 0-398-06766-X.

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Social psychologists will feel right at home with this newest text on aging. Social structuralists, on the other hand, will feel frustrated. It is not that Falk and Falk ignore social structure; they whet our appetite with it, but then fail to deliver the entire meal. The authors begin with a psychological discussion of prejudice and then introduce us to the term *gerontophobia*: a fear and/or loathing of older people. They argue that gerontophobia is a learned psychic response that leads to